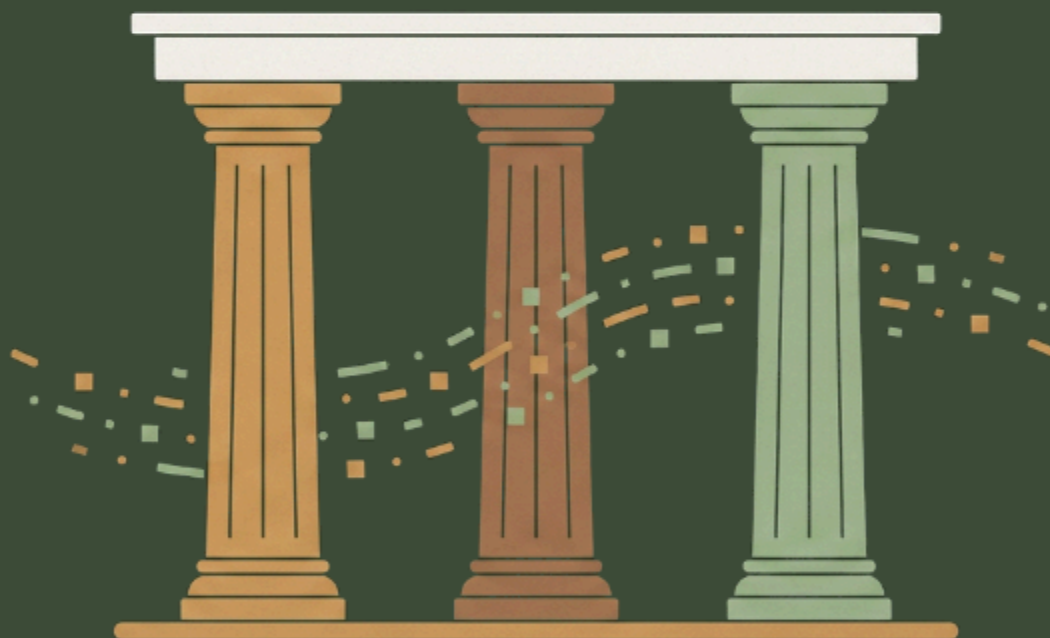


The role of the academic publisher in the age of AI

What AI disrupts in a 360-year-old institution.



Publishers are trust institutions.

In 1665, the Royal Society had a problem. Discoveries were being claimed in anagrams and sealed letters.

Philosophical Transactions was the answer. Stand behind a claim publicly, on a date.

Books, journals, and platforms are vehicles for that trust. Every disruption since changed how the function was performed. Never whether it was performed at all.

Trust rests on three load-bearing pillars.

They broadly follow the lifecycle of scholarly work.

1

Curation

Sourcing, selection, development, peer review, certification. Everything before the work exists in finished form.

2

Circulation

Registration, distribution, discoverability, access, licensing. Connecting the work with the readers who need it.

3

Continuity

Archiving, citability, stewardship. Preserving the work and its credentials across time.

AI brings three structural shifts.

THE INTERFACE

From search to agents. Researchers ask and expect answers, not lists of links.

THE CONSUMER

From human readers to machine consumers. Content can touch dozens of agents in a single query.

THE UNIT

From articles and PDFs to knowledge objects. Fragments with context, not files.

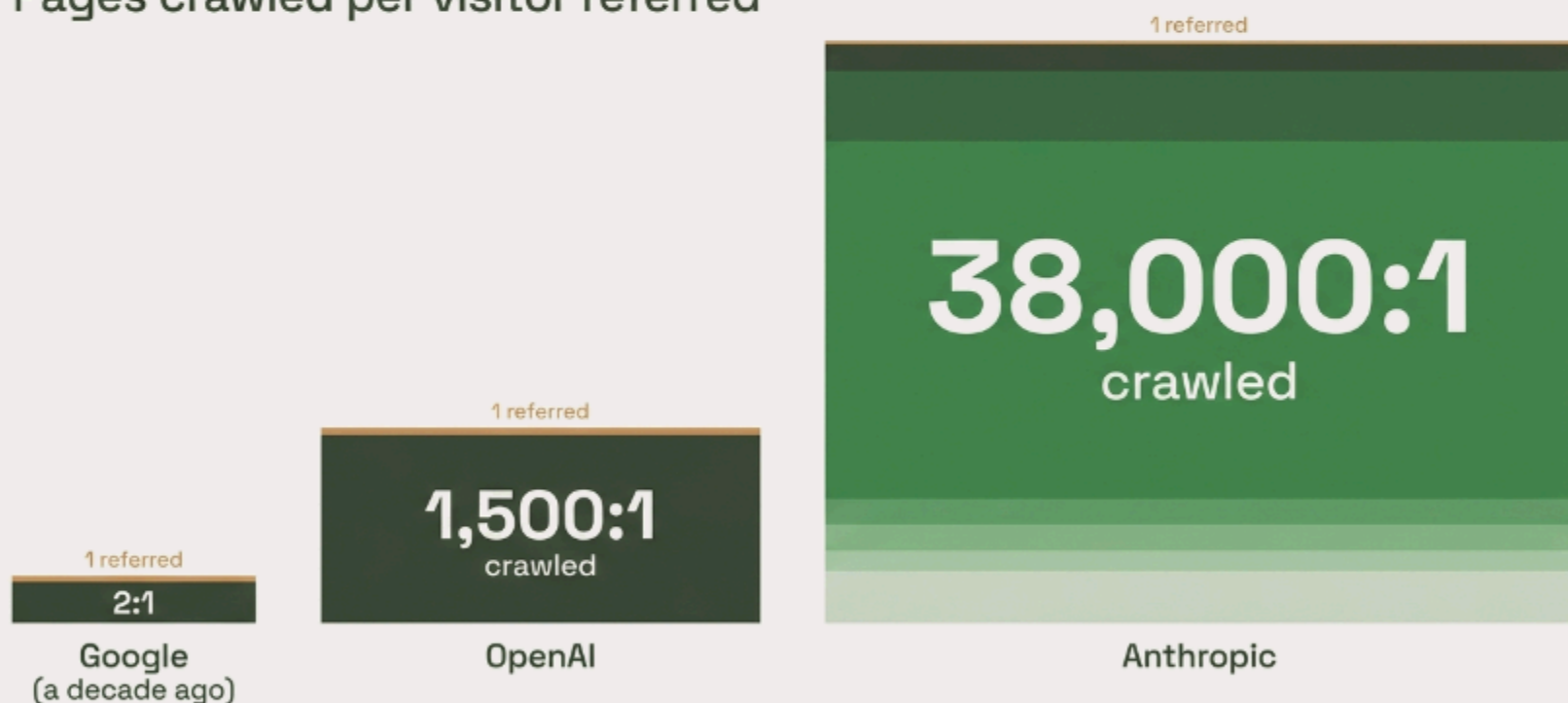
Circulation is being captured.

Discovery, reading, and attribution are moving into AI infrastructure the press doesn't control.

AI systems consume the work at scale and send almost nothing back (Cloudflare crawl-to-referral data).

Crawled vs. Referred

Pages crawled per visitor referred



The curation toolkit commoditizes. The judgment doesn't.

THE TOOLKIT COMMODITIZED BY AI	THE JUDGMENT STRUCTURALLY DEFENSIBLE
Screening, copyediting, plagiarism checks.	Selection, peer review, certification.
Cost falls as AI improves.	Value rises as AI-polished work spreads.
Anyone can run the tools.	Only a press can stake a reputation.

Surface signals no longer correlate with rigor. Accountability is what separates them.

Continuity: the table-stakes pillar is inverting.



AI INFRASTRUCTURE

Models deprecated on 12 to 24 month cycles.

Outputs are not reproducible.

Companies pivot, get acquired, wind down.



THE SCHOLARLY RECORD

A 1926 monograph is still readable today.

Citations must resolve for decades.

Verification depends on persistence.

The loudest layer of scholarly communication is becoming the most ephemeral.

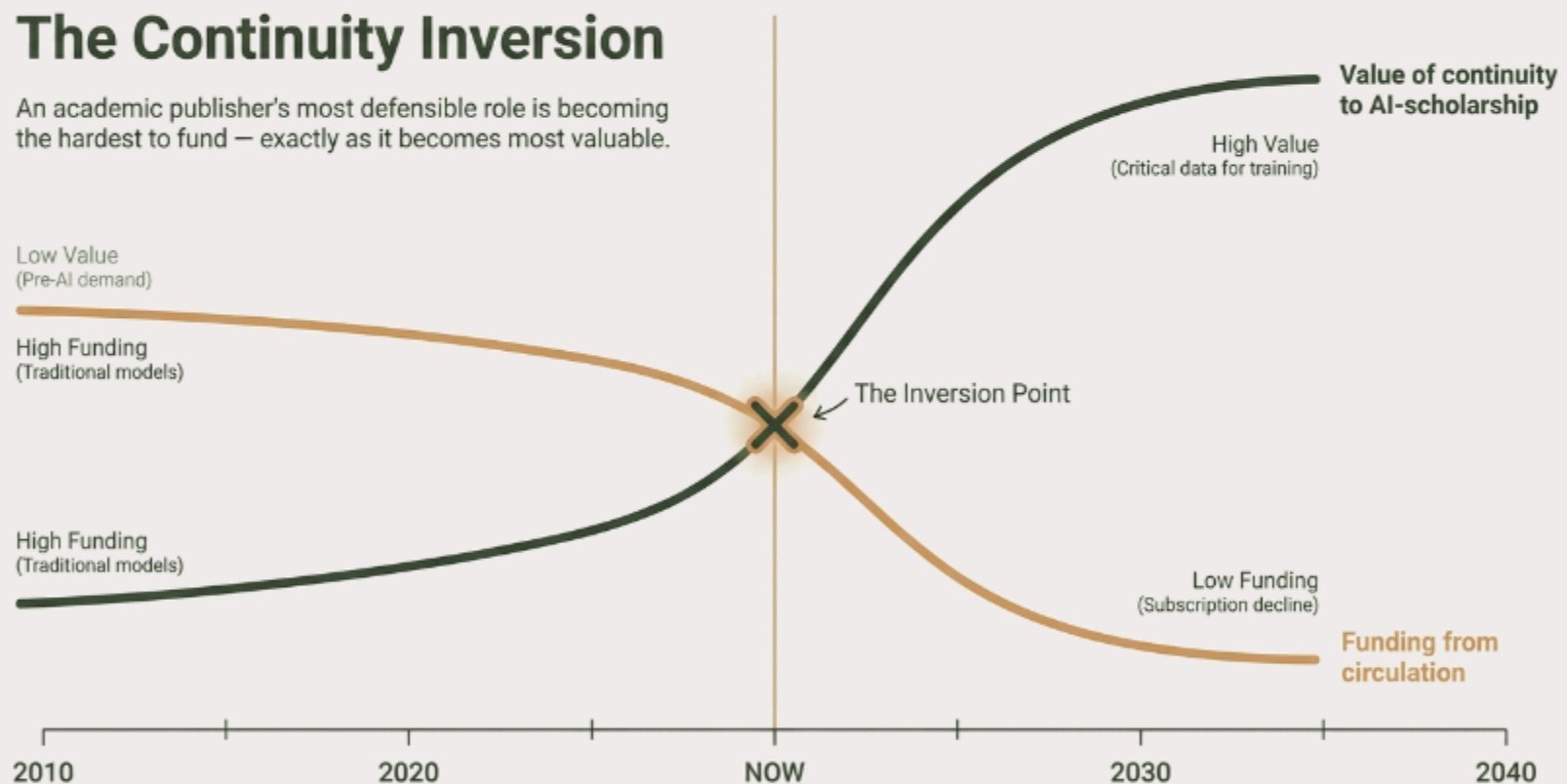
The funding paradox.

Continuity's funding has always lived inside circulation.
Subscriptions, platform access, book and journal sales.

That mechanism is collapsing at exactly the moment the
role becomes most valuable.

The Continuity Inversion

An academic publisher's most defensible role is becoming
the hardest to fund — exactly as it becomes most valuable.



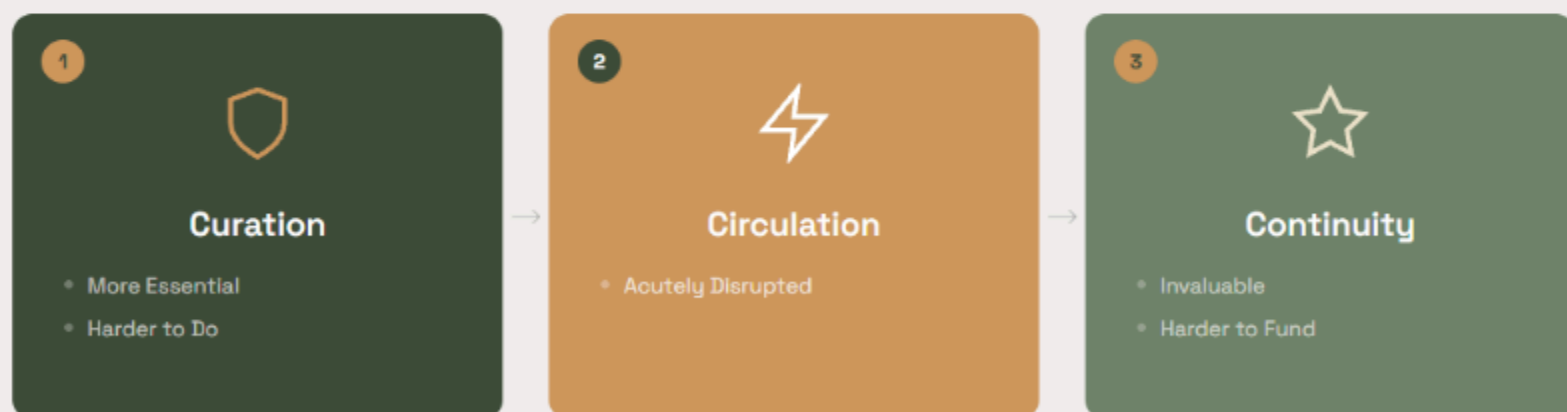
Three pillars. Three different kinds of pressure.

Curation is being tested. The role survives, but the practice has to evolve.

Circulation is being captured. The role the press plays is being routed around.

Continuity is becoming more valuable while becoming harder to fund.

The strongest argument for the press lives in the pillar that is hardest to fund.



AI doesn't break trust. It changes which pillars must carry it.

Cashmere builds AI infrastructure that helps publishers monitor, control, and monetize their content in AI systems.

Visit cashmere.io